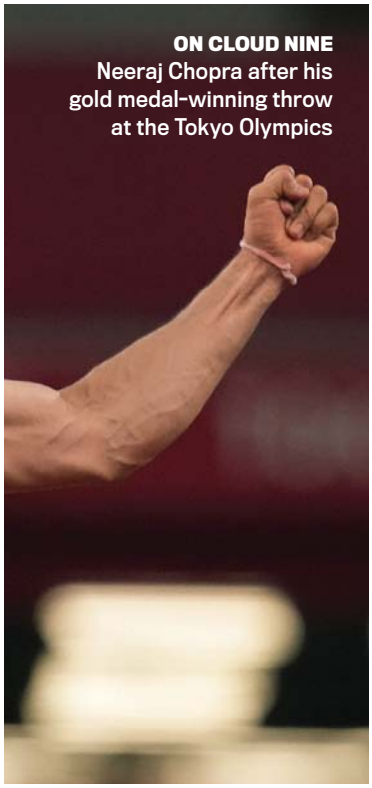


ON CLOUD NINE
Neeraj Chopra after his gold medal-winning throw at the Tokyo Olympics

GURINDER OSAN/PTI

FIRING INTO FAME

› GREAT EXPECTATIONS
Having accomplished his dream to win an Olympic gold, next up for Chopra is entering the 90-metre club. Only 20 athletes have gone past the distance

› ROLE MODEL
Czech javelin thrower Jan Železný. "He isn't as popular as he should be but he was one of the most consistent," says Chopra

› RISING STAR
Chopra has received cash awards worth at least Rs 17 crore, sizeable money for an athlete who doesn't have a chunky annual salary like national team cricketers do

› 12
The number of brands Chopra endorses

"Neeraj Chopra has the potential to be one of our greatest athletes of all time. You can only do that when you achieve your fullest potential. So, respect your passion"

ABHINAV BINDRA
Olympic gold medal-winning shooter

behind-the-scenes controversies than memorable performances on the pitch. India lost to New Zealand in the World Test Championships Finals and failed to make it to the semi-finals of the T20 World Cup after being comprehensively beaten by Pakistan and New Zealand in the group stage. Soon, Virat Kohli left his post as T20 captain and the BCCI (Board of Control for Cricket in India) picked Rohit Sharma to lead the team. Later, the BCCI would designate Sharma as captain for the ODIs too; Kohli says he was blindsided by the decision.

With India's most popular sportsperson struggling for form, Indians found a new sporting icon to root for in Chopra. While Chopra went into the Olympics Games Village as a strong medal hopeful, he didn't let the occasion overwhelm him, coming across as an athlete who knew he was destined for big things. After all, he had made his case back in 2016 with the U20 World Championship title. At the India Today Conclave in October 2021, Manisha Malhotra, head of the sports excellence programme and talent scouting at JSW Sports, described Chopra as an ideal case study of the new-age Indian athlete. "The amount of self-confidence and self-belief they have is unbelievable. They walk around with a chip on their shoulder and believe they are at par, if not better than everybody else. I think this will be the best thing to happen to Indian sport in the next decade," she said.

For Chopra, Olympics was the moment he had waited for all along. Recovering from a back injury, he had resumed competing in 2020 only to see the Covid-19 pandemic put the sporting calendar in disarray. The Tokyo Games were delayed by a year and most international competitions cancelled. As the world gradually opened up in 2021, Chopra urged government authorities, including the Sports Authority of India, to facilitate his international travel for training and competition. The two months spent preparing abroad reaped dividends on August 7.

A single throw of 87.58 metres has changed Chopra's life. His social media following has skyrocketed. He's now a sought after face for brands and magazine covers. Getting mobbed by fans is routine now. Chopra is unfazed by the attention and adulation that has come his way. His humble origins, cool temperament and fun Instagram reels have only added to his appeal. That he is fashion conscious and an unabashed believer in retail therapy has seen even those not inclined towards sports embrace him.

With age on his side and the Paris Games less than three years away, Chopra doesn't want to rest on his many laurels. There's a hunger to excel more, to cross the 90-metre mark that a few of his rivals have. "I have a habit...I keep my medal aside when I want to focus on the next goal," Chopra said at the India Today Conclave. In 2022, Chopra will be looking to add another Asian Games gold to his collection and perform well in the Diamond League circuit. With his positive attitude and hard work, the results are expected to be nothing less than gold standard. ■